RAMBAM'S INTRODUCTION TO HELEK: OLAM HABA & THE 13 PRINCIPLES

Thirteen Foundations: Why Principles of Faith?

Rambam's Introduction to Helek, Part 7

Source: The Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek: the introduction to the 13 Principles, and the start of the First Principle

Shiur: Part 7 of the series on the Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek, given by Dayan Daniel Kada on Zoom, Tuesday 18 November 2025 (the week of Chayei Sarah)

These notes are based on the transcript of the recording.

Where We Are

On **כל ישראל יש להם חלק לעולם הבא**, the Rambam explained **Olam HaBa** and its "corollary" forms (Gan Eden, Gehinom, Mashiach, resurrection): **Olam HaBa is the essence of everything we do.** Now:

ומה שצריך שנזכיר בכאן, והוא הראוי מכל המקומות, שעיקרי דתנו ויסודותיה שלשה עשר יסודות.

Here is the most fitting place: **the roots (*ikkarim*) of our religion and its foundations are thirteen.**

Since the Mishnah discusses who **has no portion**, this is where to set out **the foundations**. **"He's in his twenties, and he's the first to do this."**

Part 1: The First Jewish Creed

"Judaism has a dogma of dogmalessness": a line attributed to **Moses Mendelssohn**, and argued by some Jewish academics: Judaism is about **practice**, not belief. "**That is completely wrong, in my opinion, and definitely in the Rambam's.**"

There are beliefs every Jew must hold, **scattered** across Torah and Chazal. **Rav Saadia** (Monday nights) says *we must believe in Mashiach, in resurrection*, **but made no list**. **The Rambam (12th century) is the first to collate a creed.** "That part, everyone can agree is authentic. **The emphasis** is uniquely his": **intellect** in serving Hashem; **mitzvot must be accompanied by understanding**.

Belief over practice: the convert

The Gemara (Yevamot 47a)	The Rambam (Issurei Bi'ah 14:1–2)
Why convert? Don't you see Israel is afflicted, oppressed, harried? If he says *I know, and I'm unworthy*, **accept him immediately**	**The same**, almost word for word
Teach him some lighter and some weightier mitzvot; **leket, shichechah, pe'ah, ma'aser ani**; **the punishment** (*until now forbidden fat and Shabbat carried no karet or stoning; now they do*) and **reward**	**ומודיעין אותו עיקרי הדת, שהוא יחוד השם ואיסור עבודה זרה, ומאריכין בדבר הזה. Teach him the foundations of the faith, Hashem's unity and the prohibition of idolatry, *and elaborate at length.*** Then some mitzvot, **ואין מאריכין בדבר זה: and don't elaborate**

"**He's turned the Gemara on its head**, and added something **he made up himself**. How can he? **For the Rambam it was obvious**: you can't accept a convert who doesn't know **the fundamentals of belief**." (Halachot 3 and 4, on Olam HaBa, **are** from the Gemara, "and we still say them at the end of a conversion today.")

Part 2: The Thirteen at a Glance

	#	Principle
God	1	**Hashem exists**
	2	**Hashem is one**
	3	**Hashem is incorporeal**: no body, no physicality
	4	**Creation from nothing** (what that means isn't simple)
	5	**Worship Hashem alone**: no *avodah zarah*
Revelation	6	**Prophecy**
	7	**Moshe is the greatest prophet**
	8	**Torah from heaven**
	9	**The Torah won't change**
Reward and punishment	10	**Hashem knows our actions**
	11	**He rewards good and punishes evil**
	12	**Mashiach will come**
	13	**Resurrection**

Part 3: It Took Time to Be Accepted

Today everyone says *13*. "It wasn't so simple."

Who	How many
The Rambam	**13**
Rav Yosef Albo (*Sefer HaIkkarim*, Spain, 1400s)	**3**: **God, revelation, reward and punishment**. *If there's a Creator, He'd reveal His will; if He did, there must be consequences*
Rav Chasdai Crescas	**A different formulation** (as the Radbaz puts it, really **one**)
The Radbaz (Rav David ben Zimra, Egypt, 1500s, Responsa 344)	**None**

שאלת ממני על עיקרי הדת, על איזה חשבון אני מסכים: the Rambam's 13, Crescas's one, or Albo's three?

אין דעתי מסכמת לשום דבר מתורתנו התמימה שהוא עיקר, לפי שכולה עיקר נאמרה מפי הגבורה. I don't agree that any part of our Torah is an *ikkar, because all of it is*.

כל האומר כל התורה כולה מן השמים חוץ מפסוק אחד הוא כופר, so every mitzvah is a root and cornerstone. ומי יכניס ראשו בין ההרים הגדולים? Who can rank a light mitzvah against a severe one? He follows Abarbanel: every detail of the Torah is a root; deny any, and you're a kofer.

"**The Radbaz has a very strong point.** So what are the 13 *above* everything else?"

Part 4: Then Why Principles at All? Three Answers

1. Rav Yosef Albo: true vs foundational

The whole Torah is *emet. Some things are also ikkarim*. The difference is **focus**: you must believe everything, **but some things need more attention**.

2. Here, ignorance is no excuse

Principle 3: Hashem has no body. The Rambam: **believe He does, and you're a heretic with no portion**, even if that's how you were **naively raised** (*Hashem sits on a throne in heaven*).

The Ra'avad: *of course He has no body* (Rav Saadia devotes an essay to it), **but greater men than you believed He did** (some **French Tosafists**). **Call them heretics for a mistake?**

The famous answer (usually said in Yiddish): ***misken***, I'm sorry for you, **but if you "believe in God" and to you "God" means a pencil, you don't believe in God.** "Saying the words doesn't make you a believer. **A physical God, however big, isn't God.** I'm sorry that's how you were taught, **but you have no understanding of Godliness.**"

Elsewhere, an honest mistake costs nothing: a naive, even "Islamic" picture of Gan Eden and Gehinom is just an error. **These 13 you must know, with no excuse. A *nebach apikoros* is also an *apikoros*.**

Mark: wasn't the Rambam reacting to Islam and Christianity around him?

"Interesting: **all 13 have sources in Torah or Chazal except the third. Nowhere** do they say Hashem has no body. It's **his own reasoning**. Rav Saadia was equally adamant." **Perhaps a reaction**: "Now I think of it, in one of his letters he writes that he formulated the 13 because **he saw great scholars, who knew all of Shas, with babyish beliefs**. I think he meant exactly this."

3. They define who is "in Klal Yisrael"

At the end of the 13:

> **וכאשר יאמין האדם אלה היסודות כולם ונתבררה אמונתו בהם, הוא נכנס בכלל ישראל, ומצוה לאהבו ולחמול עליו... ואפילו עשה כל העבירות מחמת תאותו ותגבורת יצרו הרע... וכשיפקפק אדם ביסוד מאלו היסודות, הרי זה יצא מן הכלל וכפר בעיקר, ונקרא מין ואפיקורוס וקוצץ בנטיעות, ומצוה לשנאתו ולאבדו.**

Believe them all, and you enter Klal Yisrael: we must love and care for you, **even if you've committed every sin out of desire**. **Doubt one, and you've left the community**: a *min*, an *apikoros*.

"Enter Klal Yisrael"? Wasn't he Jewish already?

Still valid	a heretic's **kiddushin** is fully binding (Shulchan Aruch); his **מומר, קידושיו קידושין**: **get** works. **A gentile's kiddushin needs no get; a heretic's does. Jewish lineage** suffices
Requires *shem Yisrael*	**Shechitah**: an *apikoros*'s shechitah isn't kosher. **The mitzvot to help and care for a fellow Jew**

Part 5: Two Later Versions

	Form	Origin
יגדל	**Poetic**	Uncertain; some say **Rabbi Daniel ben Yehudah of Rome**, early 1400s. Certainly by the late 1400s. Sung Friday night. "**The Arizal didn't like it**, not entirely clear why, so many communities don't sing it after Arvit; **the old Sephardi custom always did**"
אני מאמין באמונה שלמה	**Prose**	Uncertain. Earliest print: **a 1502 Haggadah**, at *Nirtzah*. It was in the **Livorno** Sephardi siddurim; less common in Sephardi siddurim today

"We'll compare each principle against them. **They're not always precise to the Rambam.**"

Part 6: What "Emunah" Really Means

> **ונתבררה אמונתו בהם**: his belief **has become clear** to him. That's the Rambam's ***emunah sheleimah***.

The Christian distortion. "Many concepts in English, and even in Judaism, have been **severely affected by Christian philosophy**: I've said it of **reward and punishment**, and it's true of **belief**." **The Oxford Dictionary:** *faith: strong belief... based on spiritual conviction rather than proof*. **An early Christian writer (the line is usually attributed to Tertullian):** *I believe because it is absurd.* "The more absurd, the more you need faith.**"

"That is absolutely not what *emunah means. The complete opposite."*

- אמן is the root: ותקעתיו יתד במקום נאמן, a peg in a firm place; ומצאת את לבבו נאמן לפניך, Avraham's heart steadfast; ויהי אומן את הדסה, to raise and train.

- "There's a creature in Australia I've never seen: I trust you, I believe you. That's not emunah."

***- The Ramchal: כל איש מישראל צריך שיאמין וידע: believe and know*. Emunah is tantamount to knowledge.**

- So **באמונה שלמה** isn't strictly necessary; **אני מאמין** already means it.

Rav Moshe Feinstein (Igrot Moshe): may religious parents eat at a **non-observant child's** home? A child isn't believed **as a witness** (that's *trusting* testimony). But if the parents **know with certainty** the child respects them and wouldn't deceive them, **it's *barur* to them**: **they know**. "**The difference between believing something and knowing it.** That's real *emunah*, and why it's **a lifelong project**, and why the Rambam counts it among the **613**."

Haran in the furnace

The simple meaning: Haran died **in his father's lifetime**. **וימת הרן על פני תרח אביו באור כשדים.** **Targum Yonatan ben Uziel:** Haran watched **Avraham thrown into the furnace**, undecided: ***If he comes out, I'll follow his God; if not, I won't.*** Avraham emerged unscathed, **Haran jumped in, and died.**

"One of my rabbis said: **his problem was living with doubt**: an agnostic's wager." **Pascal's wager** (believe, since 120 years' inconvenience beats eternal hell) fails, "not least because it works for **every** religion. **You can't live your life with constant doubts. Make decisions, have convictions, even if it's the wrong one.**"

Why send to Ur Kasdim for a wife?

Avraham and Sarah's kiruv in Canaan brought **thousands and tens of thousands**. Yet Yaakov's family goes down to Egypt **seventy souls**. Where did they go? **The Ran (*Derashot*): easy come, easy go**: people inspired by one shiur leave after one contrary book. **In Ur Kasdim they had such conviction they threw Avraham into a fire.** "Avraham wanted a girl **with conviction**, **even in the wrong faith**. **That's what we mean by *emunah*.**"

Part 7: The First Principle

היסוד הראשון: להאמין מציאות הבורא יתברך, והוא שיש שם נמצא שלם בכל דרכי המציאות, והוא עילת מציאות הנמצאים כלם, בו קיום מציאותם וממנו קיומם. ואל יעלה על הלב העדר מציאותו, כי בהעדר מציאותו נתבטלה מציאות כל הנמצאים ולא נשאר נמצא שיתקיים מציאותו. ואם נעלה על לבנו העדר כל הנמצאים זולתו, לא תתבטל מציאות השם יתברך ולא תגרע... כי הוא מסתפק במציאותו ודי לו בעצמו, ואין

צורך במציאות זולתו. וכל מה שזולתו מן המלאכים וגופי הגלגלים ומה שבתוכם ומה שמתחתיהם, הכל צריכים למציאותם אליו. וזה היסוד הראשון, מורה עליו הדבור אנכי ה׳ אלהיך.

"**People say the First Principle is just *believe in God*. There's much more.** He has to **define** what God means, because **a distorted understanding isn't belief in God.**"

Five elements

#	Element	Words
1	**There is a Creator** (Mishneh Torah: **מצוי ראשון**, the Primal Being)	**מציאות הבורא**
2	**He is perfect.** "**An imperfect God is an oxymoron.** A God who can't stop the bad in the world isn't God"	**שלם בכל דרכי המציאות**
3	**He is self-sufficient**, needing **nothing**, including His creations (really 2b)	**מסתפק במציאותו ודי לו בעצמו**
4	**Everything else exists only through Him, continuously**	**בו קיום מציאותם וממנו קיומם**
5	**His existence is necessary**: without Him nothing would exist; without everything else, He'd be undiminished	**אל יעלה על הלב העדר מציאותו**

The Mishneh Torah opens with exactly this, a halachic book: **יסוד היסודות ועמוד החכמות, לידע שיש שם מצוי ראשון, והוא ממציא כל נמצא.** "**You can't learn halachah until you know this properly.**" That's **ה׳ אלהים אמת**: everything else **needn't** exist; **He must.**

Against Yigdal and Ani Ma'amin

	Has	Lacks
יגדל אלהים חי וישתבח, נמצא ואין עת אל מציאותו	A God who **exists**, **beyond time**; perhaps **חי** = continually sustaining	**Perfection**, and most of the rest
אני מאמין... שהבורא יתברך שמו הוא בורא ומנהיג לכל הברואים, והוא לבדו עשה ועושה ויעשה לכל המעשים	**Creator**, and **continuous** sustainer	**Perfection**

"They're summaries. **The real thing is the Rambam.**"

Summary

1. **The Rambam is the first to formulate a creed.** "**A dogma of dogmalessness**" is wrong. His **emphasis on belief**: converts are taught **the foundations at length, mitzvot briefly**, his own addition to the Gemara.
2. **13 in three groups:** God (1–5), revelation (6–9), reward and punishment (10–13). **Not immediately accepted:** Albo 3, Crescas fewer, **the Radbaz none** (*the whole Torah is an ikkar*).

3. **Why principles?** (a) **Albo**: all true, some need **focus**; (b) **no excuse of ignorance**: a God who's "a pencil" isn't God (Ra'avad vs Rambam on corporeality, the one principle **without a source**); (c) they define **entry into Klal Yisrael**: **kiddushin** still works, **shechitah** doesn't.
4. **Yigdal and Ani Ma'amin**: later, not always precise.
5. ***Emunah* isn't "belief without proof"**: from ***amen***, firmness. **Believe and *know*** (Ramchal; Rav Moshe on the non-observant child). **Conviction**: Haran's wager; **Avraham's wife from Ur Kasdim**.
6. **Principle 1**: five elements, **Creator, perfect, self-sufficient, sustaining all, necessary**: the opening of the **Mishneh Torah**.

Coming Up

Next week: each of the five elements in depth, with **the Rishonim's arguments for God's existence** ("nowhere in Tanach or Chazal was it ever doubted; only the Rishonim began to argue it"), then **Principle 2**.

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